# My design and AI process

Stride: a running performance prototype for serious recreational runners.

## The user and task

**User:** A serious recreational runner who trains several days a week and logs every run. They have plenty of performance data but no clear reading on it.

**Task:** Help the runner answer "Am I actually getting better?" at a glance, then show what's driving it and what to try next. In the 8-week dataset, weekly mileage climbs 79% while pace improves to a best of 7:52/mi in week 4, then slows to 8:10/mi. Stride needs to surface that pattern, connect it to the likely cause (skipping rest after long runs), and recommend a concrete next week of training.

## Key design decisions

1. **Interpret the data, don't just display it.** Turn metrics into a clear, plain-language takeaway. The headline states the conclusion ("You're running more, but getting slower.") and a supporting sentence explains why, so the runner doesn't have to piece the story together from charts.
2. **Make metrics meaningful.** Use comparisons, trends, and context instead of isolated numbers. Current pace is shown against the runner's best ("18 sec/mi off your best"), mileage against week 1 (+79%), and "What changed?" compares volume, recovery and pace from before to now.
3. **Make the experience responsive.** Changing the time range updates the insight, metrics, chart, and recommendation together. The last 8 weeks reads "running more, but getting slower," while the last 2 weeks reads "holding steady," with a different recommendation for each.
4. **Create a clear hierarchy.** Move from Performance → What changed? → Try this next, with detail one click deeper in the training calendar and the run drawer. One primary chart (pace by week) answers the core question; everything else supports it or sits a click away.
5. **Use color intentionally.** Lime highlights positive performance and actions; orange highlights slowing performance and recovery opportunities. Run types use shape (circle, diamond, pill) instead of relying on color alone, and orange always appears with words, so meaning never depends on color.
6. **Keep recommendations observational.** Identify patterns and suggest something to try without diagnosing or prescribing. Recovery opportunities are measured against the runner's own history (habits they kept while improving and later dropped), and the recommendation is framed as an experiment modeled on their fastest week: "see whether your pace responds."

## Design tradeoff

**Glanceability over completeness.** My first prototype was overwhelming. It had a pattern banner, four metric cards, a combined pace-and-mileage chart, a run-type filter in the header, and a full run table with heart rate and effort, all competing for attention. Each piece was accurate, but together they buried the one question the page needs to answer. I had to iterate continuously, over 15 rounds, cutting, merging and moving things one click deeper until the page read in seconds. Along the way I removed the metric cards, the mileage bars, the second chart and the homepage run-type filter.

- **What I gave up:** runners who want to filter by run type or see heart rate and effort up front have to go one click deeper, into the training calendar or a run's detail drawer.
- **How I softened it:** most of that information moved rather than disappeared. Mileage still appears as a number and comparison, the run-type filter lives in the training calendar where exploring by type makes sense, and every run's full details are one click away.
- **What would change my mind:** I'd revisit it if testing showed runners need that data on the homepage to trust the recommendation, or if power users consistently skip the summary to dig into the details.

## Partnering with AI

I used ChatGPT, Variant AI, and Claude throughout the process, with each tool serving a different purpose.

- **Variant AI** helped me quickly explore visual directions and get past the blank-canvas stage.
- **Claude Code** was where I built and iterated on the actual prototype. I fed the direction directly into Claude and used it to create the more robust interactions, responsive states, and final 16:9 graphic.
- **ChatGPT** helped me refine my prompts and think through how to get the most meaningful output with fewer iterations. I used it as a thought partner to make my instructions to Claude more specific and intentional.